

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Writing Spot: I'm so sorry for your loss.



Learning Outcome

Use expressions about relationships and feelings in a range of social and work contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can write about social activities.
- I can show I understand someone's feelings.
- I can write a short letter/e-mail to express sympathy.

Ask your partner:

- What kinds of letters have you written? Have you ever written a letter of sympathy?
- Who was it for? What did you include?



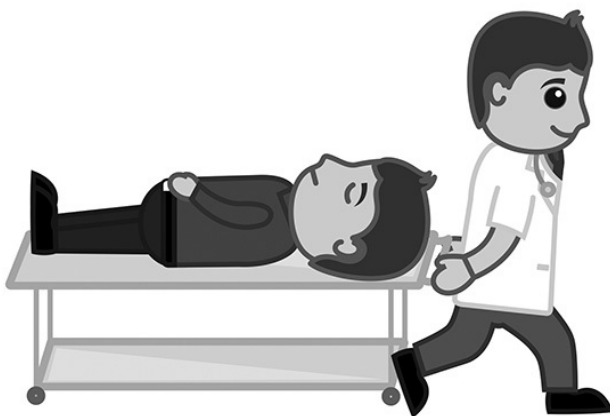


Let's Explore!

Sally, Vanessa and Peter are having a **get together***. Peter doesn't seem to **be himself****. What news did he receive?

* A "get together" is an informal gathering.

** If some appears **not** to "be himself", he is behaving in an unusual way.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

- Sally:** Hey Peter, come in. Oh, you brought some nibbles. Thanks!
- Peter:** No problem. You know I like spending time with you guys. I also downloaded some new music to my phone we can listen to later.
- Vanessa:** Hey there stranger! Ready for a *Quest For Empires* marathon? We're starting at episode two.
- Peter:** Hi Vanessa. Sounds good. We still on for a gym session tomorrow morning?
- Vanessa:** Absolutely. Hey ... are you OK? Is something wrong?
- Peter:** I just got a call from a co-worker on my way over. James's father died last night in his sleep.
- Sally:** James from work? Was his dad ill?
- Peter:** It was a massive heart attack. He was only 58.
- Vanessa:** The poor guy. It must be such a distressing time for his family.
- Sally:** How is he handling it? It must be so upsetting to receive that kind of news.
- Peter:** He was trying to be strong but I could tell he was on the verge of crying.
- Vanessa:** I would be so shocked if someone close to me suddenly passed away.
- Peter:** I'm not sure what I should do next. I was lost for words on the phone.
- Vanessa:** He needs a shoulder to lean on.
- Sally:** A letter of sympathy would also show that you are thinking about him during this difficult time. I would be so confused and angry.
- Peter:** Yeah ... a letter might be a good idea. I seem to be a little tongue-tied at the moment.



Let's Practice!

Do you ever watch a number of episodes, one after the other*?

*You can use the word *marathon* to describe watching television for a long period of time.

Instructions: Choose the words from the Word Bank to correctly complete. Use capitals where necessary.

Word Bank

downloaded / session / nibbles / quest / episode / lost

Oh, you brought some _____.

I also _____ some new music to my phone we can listen to later.

Ready for a _____ For Empires marathon?

We still on for a gym _____ tomorrow morning?

We're starting at _____ two.

I was _____ for words on the phone.



Let's Practice!

Peter was tongue-tied* on the phone when he heard the news.

*Not knowing what to say.

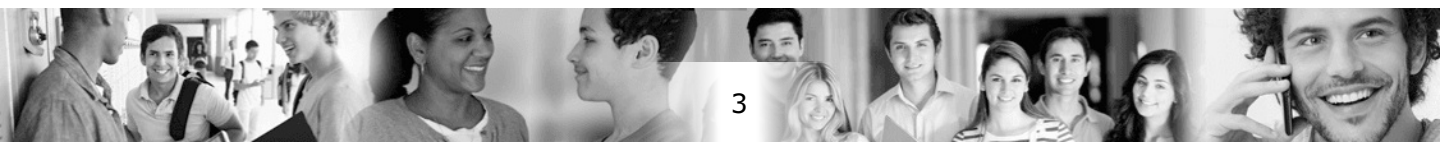
Instructions: Draw a line from column A to column B to match the correct words to complete the sentence.

COLUMN A

1. I _____ if someone close to me suddenly passed away.
2. It must _____ time for his family.
3. It _____ to receive that kind of news.
4. I would be so _____ and angry.

COLUMN B

- a. would be so shocked
- b. such a distressing
- c. must be so upsetting
- d. confused





Extension Activity

A friend asks for some advice on how to write a letter of sympathy. Do you have the answers?

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Write a 12 line dialogue between you and a friend.
- Your friend's co-worker has recently lost a family member.
- Your friend wants to write a letter of sympathy. What should they include?
- Include sentences using adjectives with -ed and -ing endings.
- Read the dialogue aloud to a partner.

Self-Assessment

Yes No

I write a dialogue giving advice on how to write a letter of sympathy.

☐ ☐

I include adjectives with -ed and -ing endings.

☐ ☐

I read the dialogue about expressing sympathy to a partner.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- nibbles** (noun): small things to eat before a meal or at a party; snacks or appetizers
e.g. Oh, you brought some nibbles.
- quest** (noun): a long and difficult effort to find or do something
e.g. Ready for a Quest For Empires marathon?
- session** (noun): a period of time that is used to do a particular activity
e.g. We still on for a gym session tomorrow morning?
- heart attack** (noun): a medical condition when your heart stops working correctly
e.g. It was a massive heart attack.
- verge** (noun): at the point when something is about to happen or is very likely to happen
e.g. He was on the verge of crying.
- to pass away** (verb): to die - used as a polite way to avoid saying the word "die"
e.g. I would be so shocked if someone close to me suddenly passed away.
- tongue-tied** (expression): to find it difficult to respond to information
e.g. I seem to be a little tongue-tied at the moment.
- condolences** (noun): feelings or expressions of sympathy especially after the loss of someone in a family
e.g. I want to express my condolences to you and your family.





Learning Points

Writing a personal letter/e-mail to express sympathy

You write a sympathy letter to honour the life of the deceased and to support their family and friends. It is important the information contained in the letter expresses sympathy, kindness and support.

Letters of sympathy are written, not typed, and are kept fairly short. Think about what you would want someone to say to you if you were in this difficult situation.

Letters of sympathy include:

- How you heard about the news and your reaction
- Your sincere condolences to the person and the rest of their family
- Your feelings about the deceased
- Any memories or personal stories
- An offering of support and assistance
- A closing that expresses affection and support

Make sure your handwriting is clear and neat. Ensure that your spelling is correct and there are no grammatical errors. Proofread your letter before you send it.

Examples:

- *I am so sorry to hear about the tragic death of your father.*
- *He was one of the kindest, most generous people we knew.*

Show you understand someone's feelings or situation

You use a **modal** like *must*, *would* or *could* followed by an adjective when you want to empathize with someone. When you empathize, you show someone that you understand the situation and how badly they feel.

To talk about situations, use the *-ing* form of the adjective.

To talk about feelings, use the *-ed* form of the adjective.

Here is the structure to follow:

subject + modal + verb + adjective

Don't forget to include the verb before the adjective.

Examples:

- *It must be so upsetting to receive that kind of news.*
- *I would be so shocked if I someone close to me suddenly passed away.*
- *It must be such a distressing time for his family.*

